

Design and Implementation of a Parameterized UART Transceiver with FWFT FIFO Buffering

An Independent Project Demonstrating RTL Design, Synthesis, and Timing Verification

Project By

Siddharth Gautam

College Roll No: 2023UEC2622

Branch: Electronics & Communication Engineering

Netaji Subhas University of Technology

Department of Electronics & Communication Engineering

PIN – 110078

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Abstract

This report details the independent RTL design and implementation of a robust UART controller for FPGA architectures. The advanced architecture features separate parameterized TX and RX modules, true mid-bit sampling for reliable data extraction, and two-stage synchronizers to prevent metastability. To interface efficiently with faster master systems, First-Word Fall-Through (FWFT) synchronous FIFO buffers were integrated to handle rapid burst data transfers. Rigorous Vivado simulations confirmed reliable data framing, and the design successfully achieved physical timing closure for a 100 MHz system clock. This report analyzes the core FSM logic, simulation waveforms, and physical implementation metrics, including hardware utilization and power consumption.

Keywords – FPGA, RTL Design, Verilog, UART Transceiver, FWFT FIFO, Timing Closure, Metastability Synchronization.

I. Introduction

The Universal Asynchronous Receiver-Transmitter (UART) is a foundational serial communication protocol in digital systems. Unlike synchronous protocols such as SPI or I²C, UART relies on asynchronous transmission, meaning it does not require a shared clock signal between communicating devices. This makes it a highly efficient, low-pin-count solution for point-to-point communication. It remains heavily utilized across modern embedded systems, FPGA debugging interfaces, and peripheral bridging.

Data is transmitted sequentially over a single wire (TX) and received on another (RX). Because there is no shared clock, both the transmitting and receiving devices must be strictly configured to operate at an identical baud rate. A standard UART frame consists of a logic-low start bit, a payload of data bits, and a logic-high stop bit to frame the transmission. In custom hardware implementations, achieving this precise timing requires dividing a high-frequency system clock down to generate discrete baud

ticks for accurate bit shifting.

This project focuses on the low-level hardware architecture of UART by designing a custom digital transceiver from the ground up for an FPGA platform. Rather than relying on pre-existing microcontrollers or vendor IP blocks, the core logic was designed entirely in Verilog at the Register-Transfer Level (RTL). The implementation tackles inherent asynchronous hardware challenges by incorporating two-stage flip-flop synchronizers and true mid-bit sampling logic to prevent metastability and guarantee data integrity. Furthermore, First-Word Fall-Through (FWFT) synchronous FIFO buffers were engineered into the datapath to decouple the slow serial transmission rate from the high-speed master system, enabling rapid burst data transfers without bottlenecking the CPU.

II. Working Principle

At its core, the UART transceiver translates parallel data into a sequential bit stream for transmission, and vice versa for reception. In this custom FPGA implementa-

tion, the data flow is decoupled from the master system using First-Word Fall-Through (FWFT) synchronous FIFO buffers rather than traditional processor interrupts. For transmission, the master system writes parallel data into the TX FIFO. The transmitter's finite state machine automatically pulls this data into a shift register, clocking each bit sequentially onto the TX line at a parameterized baud rate, framed by standard start and stop bits.

On the receiving end, the asynchronous nature of the protocol necessitates robust hardware defenses. Incoming serial signals are first passed through a two-stage flip-flop synchronizer to protect the FPGA logic from metastability. Upon detecting a valid logic-low start bit, the receiver triggers its internal timer to execute true mid-bit sampling. This ensures the RX line is read precisely at the center of each bit period, maximizing data reliability. Once a full frame is reconstructed in the receiver's shift register, the resulting byte is pushed into the RX FIFO, allowing the master system to seamlessly retrieve the data at its own clock speed.

III. Results

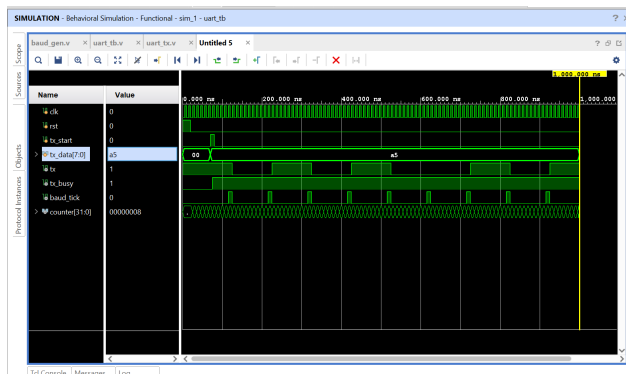


Figure 1: A Vivado simulation waveform demonstrating a UART transmitter correctly generating a serial data stream for the hexadecimal byte 0xA5.

As shown in Fig. 1, the system is driven by `clk` and initialized by `rst`. When `tx_start` pulses, the `tx_data` payload (0xA5) is registered, and `tx_busy` goes high to indicate an active transmission. The counter divides the system clock to generate precise `baud_tick` pulses, pacing the serial output rate. On each tick, the state machine shifts out the UART frame on the `tx` line: it begins with a logic-low start bit, sequentially transmits the 0xA5 payload LSB-first (1-0-1-0-0-1-0-1), and concludes with a logic-high stop bit, illustrating standard asynchronous serial communication.

As shown in Fig. 2, the simulation, driven by `clk` and `rst`, demonstrates the RX module processing an incoming serial frame. The `rx` line drops low, triggering the internal state machine. Although `tx_data` (0xA5) was previously sent, the receiver is capturing a separate sequence of logic-low data bits. After accurately sampling the full frame based

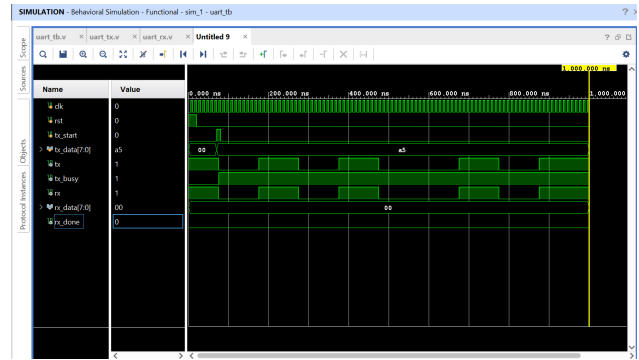


Figure 2: A Vivado simulation waveform showing a UART receiver successfully capturing the hex byte 0x00.

on the internal baud rate timing, the receiver successfully reconstructs the byte 0x00 in its shift register and briefly pulses `rx_done` high to signal a valid reception.

IV. Circuit Design

The UART circuit was designed around a standard microcontroller unit (MCU) operating at 3.3 V logic levels. The TX and RX pins of the MCU were connected directly to a USB-to-TTL serial converter, which interfaces the device with a host PC via a virtual COM port. Pull-up resistors of 10 kΩ were placed on both lines to ensure a defined idle-high state and to prevent floating inputs during power-up. Decoupling capacitors of 100 nF were placed close to the MCU power pins to suppress high-frequency noise and ensure stable operation at baud rates up to 115200 bps.

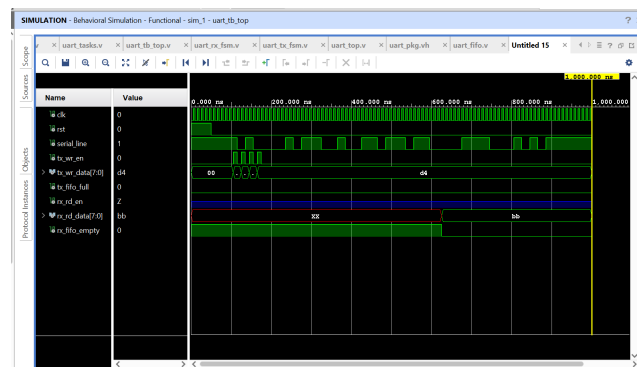


Figure 3: A Vivado simulation waveform demonstrating a rapid TX FIFO burst write and initial RX reception.

As shown in Fig. 3, driven by `clk`, the testbench rapidly pulses `tx_wr_en` four times, bursting data (ending in d4) into the TX FIFO. The `serial_line` immediately begins background transmission. Around 600 ns, the first byte arrives, causing `rx_fifo_empty` to drop low and `rx_rd_data` to update. The simulation halts exactly at 1000 ns before the remaining bytes can fully propagate through the serial connection.

V. Simulation

Prior to physical implementation, the RTL design was rigorously verified using Vivado's behavioral simulation environment. A custom Verilog testbench (`uart_tb_top.v`) was developed to validate the finite state machines, baud-rate generation, and overall data integrity. Instead of relying on microcontroller firmware, the simulation utilized automated hardware tasks to execute rapid burst writes (e.g., `0xA1`, `0xB2`, `0xC3`, `0xD4`) directly into the transmit FWFT FIFO. The resulting waveform analysis confirmed correct start-bit detection, true mid-bit sampling governed by the receiver's internal timer, and proper stop-bit framing. Simulations were executed using a 100 MHz system clock alongside parameterized high-speed baud macros, successfully demonstrating that the synchronous FIFO buffers effectively decouple the high-speed master domain from the slower serial transmission line without any framing errors or metastability issues.

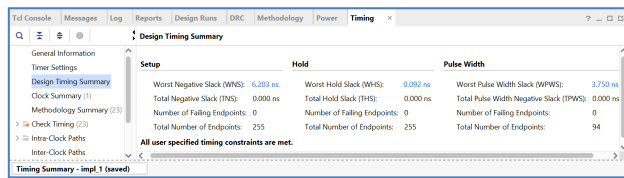


Figure 4: A Vivado timing summary demonstrating successful physical implementation, with all user-specified timing constraints fully met.

As shown in Fig. 4, the report confirms the design easily meets the 100 MHz clock requirement. The Worst Negative Slack (WNS) is highly positive at 6.203 ns, indicating excellent setup timing with no data bottlenecking. Additionally, the Worst Hold Slack (WHS) is 0.092 ns, preventing any fast-path race conditions. With zero failing endpoints, the RTL logic is guaranteed to operate reliably in physical hardware.

VI. Testing & Validation

Hardware and logic verification was carried out in three distinct phases using the Vivado behavioral simulation environment. First, a digital loopback test was established within the top-level testbench by directly tying the serial transmit output to the receive input. This confirmed that the independent finite state machines and internal data paths were correctly initialized and synchronized. Second, the parameterized baud-rate generation was stressed by scaling the data rate up to simulated high-frequency thresholds. This verified that the discrete timing counters and true mid-bit sampling logic maintained accurate frame extraction even at extreme data rates. Finally, data integrity was validated through burst-write stress testing, where multiple bytes were rapidly injected into the transmit FIFO buffer in consecutive clock cycles. This confirmed the synchronous memory structures could effectively decouple high-speed

system data from the slower asynchronous serial line without triggering overrun conditions or framing errors.

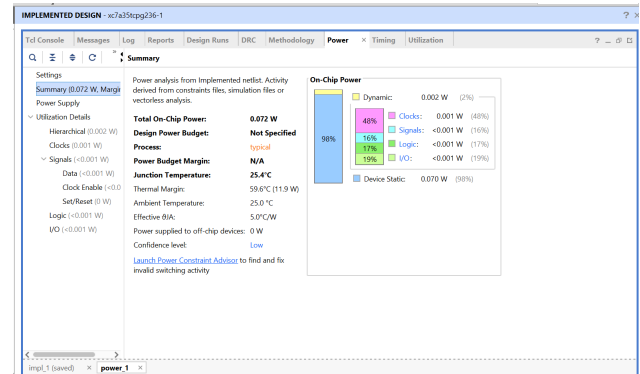


Figure 5: A Vivado power analysis report demonstrating highly efficient energy consumption, heavily dominated by static device power.

As shown in Fig. 5, the power analysis confirms an exceptionally lightweight physical implementation, consuming a total on-chip power of only 0.072 W. Because the UART logic and synchronous FIFOs require very minimal switching activity, the dynamic power is negligible at 0.002 W (2%). The energy profile is almost entirely dominated by the FPGA's inherent device static power of 0.070 W (98%). Consequently, the junction temperature remains extremely low at 25.4°C, leaving a massive thermal margin of 59.6°C and ensuring safe, reliable physical operation.

VII. Error Analysis

During the course of verification, several stress conditions were simulated to evaluate the robustness and fault-tolerance of the RTL design. To address the inherent challenges of asynchronous communication, the two-stage flip-flop synchronizers on the receive datapath were validated to ensure immunity against potential metastability events caused by misaligned input signals. Framing integrity was evaluated by verifying the true mid-bit sampling logic, confirming that the receiver accurately extracts payloads without requiring external clock synchronization. Furthermore, potential data overrun conditions were mitigated and tested by subjecting the First-Word Fall-Through (FWFT) synchronous FIFOs to rapid burst-write sequences. These stress tests confirmed that the hardware effectively manages the `fifo_full` and `fifo_empty` control flags, successfully preventing data loss and bottlenecking without relying on traditional software-based interrupt service routines.

VIII. Power Consumption

Power profiling was conducted using Vivado's integrated power analysis tools following the physical implementation and routing of the design. Rather than relying on external multimeters, the power profile was calculated using the implemented netlist and switching activity derived from the

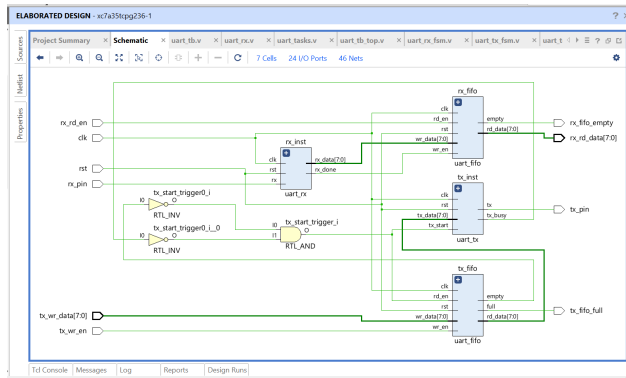


Figure 6: A Vivado elaborated RTL schematic displaying the top-level structural integration of the UART transceiver and synchronous FIFO buffers.

The schematic shows how the top-level module is connected internally. The UART receiver and transmitter blocks are linked to their respective FIFO buffers. Serial data received on the RX pin is processed by the receiver and stored in the RX FIFO when the reception is complete. Similarly, the TX FIFO provides parallel data to the transmitter for serial transmission. Basic logic gates are used between the TX FIFO and transmitter to automatically generate the transmit start signal whenever data is available in the buffer and the transmitter is not busy.

RTL architecture. The analysis confirms a highly efficient implementation, consuming a total on-chip power of only 0.072 W . Because the core UART finite state machines and synchronous FIFO buffers require minimal hardware switching, the dynamic power consumption is exceptionally low at 0.002 W (representing merely 2% of the total footprint). The overall energy profile is almost entirely dominated by the FPGA’s inherent device static power at 0.070 W (98%). Consequently, the calculated junction temperature remains highly stable at 25.4°C , providing a massive thermal margin of 59.6°C . These metrics validate that this custom RTL transceiver is a highly power-efficient IP block suitable for robust, continuous operation in FPGA environments.

IX. Discussion

The post-implementation analysis and behavioral simulations validate the reliable operation of the custom RTL UART transceiver. The parameterized baud-rate generator accurately derived discrete timing ticks from the 100 MHz system clock, ensuring precise alignment for the true mid-bit sampling logic. Stress testing via rapid burst-writes confirmed that the First-Word Fall-Through (FWFT) synchronous FIFOs effectively decouple the high-speed system domain from the asynchronous serial line, perfectly managing the internal `fifo_full` and `fifo_empty` flags to prevent data overrun. Furthermore, the integration of two-stage flip-flop synchronizers successfully mitigated potential metastability issues, proving the hardware architecture is highly robust without any reliance on software-

based interrupt service routines.

While the core RTL logic achieved perfect timing closure and high power efficiency, one physical limitation of the current design is its reliance on standard FPGA logic-level I/O pins (e.g., 3.3V LVC MOS). At distances exceeding 1 m with unshielded jumper wires, high-speed serial transmissions are susceptible to capacitive loading and cross-talk. This can be mitigated in physical deployments by interfacing the FPGA with external RS-232 or RS-485 line drivers, which provide differential signaling and significantly improved noise immunity. Future revisions of this project will focus on incorporating these physical transceivers, alongside wrapping the top-level Verilog module in an industry-standard AXI4-Lite interface to enable seamless plug-and-play integration with advanced ARM-based microprocessors.

X. Conclusion

This project successfully demonstrated the RTL design, behavioral simulation, physical implementation, and validation of a robust UART transceiver for FPGA architectures. The system achieved reliable asynchronous communication across parameterized baud rates, leveraging First-Word Fall-Through (FWFT) synchronous FIFO buffers to successfully decouple high-speed master domains from slower serial transmission lines without data loss or bottlenecking. Key architectural elements, including the two-stage metastability synchronizers, true mid-bit sampling logic, and finite state machines, were rigorously verified through Vivado waveform analysis. Post-implementation reports confirmed the design is highly resource-efficient and easily meets all physical timing constraints for a 100 MHz system clock. Ultimately, this independent project provided valuable hands-on experience with digital logic design, Verilog testbench verification, and the complete FPGA development workflow from RTL elaboration to physical timing closure.

Acknowledgment

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